approach" to the Strait crisis was possible. Nonetheless, he was somewhat taken aback when he heard that Zhou's response was "quite friendly."[211]

Dulles believed that Nehru's pessimism had stemmed from his desire to keep Krishna Menon involved as an intermediary.[212] But, by June 1955, Nehru believed that direct, preferably informal, Sino-US negotiations were the only effective option. He disagreed with the Sino-Soviet call for a six-power conference to discuss Far Eastern issues because he had come to believe that large conferences involved too much back and forth on issues like participants. Furthermore, issues like Taiwan were best dealt with bilaterally.[213] He did not expect a Taiwan solution, but told the Indonesian prime minister that direct talks could alleviate tensions related to the offshore islands, which could create a better atmosphere more broadly.[214] Finally, Nehru believed there was a limit to how much India could achieve as an intermediary; he was frustrated with the Chinese attitude on American prisoners, believing that their continued detention gave the Eisenhower administration an excuse to rile up anti-China opinion.[215]

There was another reason for Indian reticence to becoming involved again between China and the US: the impact on US-India relations. Nehru worried about the effect of the US seeing Indian policymakers as "stronger advocates of [the] Chinese position than [the] Chinese themselves.[216] In his talks with Dulles, Krishna Menon repeatedly asserted that Indian policy toward China was not anti-American; instead, India actually wanted to "help increase and promote the prestige of the United States throughout Asia." He stressed that he did not want India's mediation and differences over China to affect the US-India relationship negatively or result in the US questioning India's motives.[217]

Some members of Congress were, at the very least, questioning India's wisdom. In hearings, they expressed frustration about India's naïveté about China. They invoked the Munich analogy, as well as the metaphor of lambs lying down with lions. Others asked if Delhi did not realize that growing Chinese strength would decrease India's prestige in Asia.[218] Moreover, there was frustration that India had helped increase China's global respectability.[219]

India's improving relations with China and then, in 1955, the Soviet Union, also gave Delhi's critics on Capitol Hill more ammunition. That summer, while advocating for aid to India, Allen acknowledged, "There are